# CHINEMELU OKAFOR

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HARVARD UNIVERSITY

## Education

**Harvard Government Department** — Cambridge, MA
Ph.D. Government, *Karl Deutsch Fellow* — May 2028

**Harvard Government Department** — Cambridge, MA
A.M. Government — May 2025

**Princeton University** — Princeton, NJ
Emerging Scholars in Politics Program — August 2021

**The George Washington University** — Washington, DC
M.A. Applied Economics, *Dean's Award* — May 2018

**University of Michigan** — Ann Arbor, MI
B.A. Economics & International Studies — May 2015

## Primary Fields

Comparative politics, political economy, public economics

## Secondary Fields

Economic development, cultural economics, narrative economics

## References

**Melani Cammett (Chair)**
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**Nathan Nunn**
University of British Columbia
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**Awa Ambra Seck**
Harvard Business School
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**Pia Raffler**
Harvard University
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**Mashail Malik**
Harvard University
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**Belinda Archibong**
Johns Hopkins University
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## Working Papers

**Protest Matters: The Effects of Protests on Economic Redistribution** (with Belinda Archibong, Evans Osabuohien and Tom Moerenhout). Reject and Resubmit, *Review of Economics and Statistics* [NBER working paper, 2026].


**Abstract:** Can citizen-led protests lead to meaningful economic redistribution? We study the effects of protests on fiscal redistribution using evidence from Nigeria. We digitized twenty-six years of public finance data from 1988 to 2016 to examine the effects of protests on intergovernmental transfers. We find that protests increase transfers to protesting regions, but only in areas that are politically aligned with disbursing governments. Two natural experiments- the large-scale 2012 Occupy Nigeria protests and 2015 presidential election- validate these results. Protesters also face increased police violence, particularly in non-aligned regions. The results show that protests can influence fiscal redistribution.


**The Origins of Women's Economic and Political Participation in Africa.** [Draft available upon request].

**Abstract:** Women's economic participation is not uniform across the world. Africa continues to stand out in its singular ability to engage women in the economy both in terms of levels of female labor force participation and heterogeneity. While the dominant explanation for women's (dis) empowerment elsewhere points to the historical introduction of the plough, Africa had nearly no exposure to plough technologies and instead was primarily characterized by hoe-farming. Still, African ethnic groups exhibited substantial historical variation in the extent to which women played a dominant role in agriculture. What, then, explains the origins of women's economic participation across Africa? I argue that whether contemporary African women participate in the labor force is in part driven by differences in historical norms developed from ethnic groups' gendered farming practices which were themselves driven by tasks necessary for crop cultivation. In the absence of plough machinery, societies considered reaping men's tasks and considered sowing and weeding women's tasks. This gendered division of tasks effectively gave rise to distinctly men's and women's crops across the continent. To test this, I link pre-colonial ethnic group data on whether women worked more (or only) in agriculture to gendered folklore motifs data, present-day female labor force participation data and data on political participation across the continent. I instrument for women's historical role in agriculture using exogenous grid cell-level crop suitability data and the historical crop classification of men's and women's crops established by social anthropologist Hermann Baumann. I find empirical evidence that women's historical economic participation in the economy, amongst societies more suitable for women's crops, predicts women's participation in the economy and household decision-making autonomy. The results also suggest that ethnic groups in areas more suitable for women's crops exhibit fewer gender motifs depicting female domesticity, female submission, and male violence in their historical folklore.

## Works in Progress

**What's in a Name? Toponyms, Origin Myths and Women's Economic Empowerment in Africa.**
Do "female-named" communities reflect a social history that has led to more economic empowerment for women in some areas today?

**Cultural Festivals and the Persistence of Gender Norms Concerning Women's Work:** Evidence from an Encouragement Design in Nigeria.
Do cultural festivals, specifically annual harvest festivals celebrating "women's crops," generate the common knowledge necessary for progressive gender norms to be advocated for?

**The Effects of Women-Led Protests on Gender Gaps in Political Participation** (with Belinda Archibong, Nonso Obikili and Oluseye Ajuwon).
Can protests lead to meaningful changes in political participation, particularly among marginalized groups like women?

## Fellowships & Grants

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|---|---|
| Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, *Dissertation Writing Fellowship* | August 2026 |
| Econometric Society Africa Summer School | July 2026 |
| Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Mid-dissertation Grant | April 2026 |
| Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Pre-dissertation Grant *(x2)* | April 2026 |
| John C. Hansen & Katherine Vogelheim, Research Grant | January 2026 |
| Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, GSA Grant *(x2)* | October 2026 |
| Harvard Center for African Studies, Travel Grant | May 2025 |
| Association for Comparative Economic Studies Summer School (*fully funded)* | July 2025 |
| Harvard Government Department, Women and Politics Research Grant | April 2025 |
| Harvard Jens Aubrey Westengard Scholarship | May 2024 |
| Forbes 30 Under 30 N. America: Education - Founder, Research in Color Foundation | November 2022 |
| Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Summer Language Grant | April 2022 |
| Harvard Graduate School of Arts and Sciences *Graduate Prize Fellowship* | August 2021 |
| Harvard Department of Government *Karl Deutsch Fellowship* | August 2021 |
| American Political Science Association *Diversity Fellowship* | December 2020 |
| Best Overall Performance in the Applied Economics Master's Program, *Dean's Award* | May 2018 |

## Teaching Experience

**Harvard Department of Government** — Cambridge, MA
Teaching Fellow for Matt Reichert — Spring 2026
Research Practice in Qualitative Methods

**Harvard Department of Government** — Cambridge, MA
Honors Thesis Advisor; Advisee awarded — Spring 2026
*Philippe Wamba Prize* for the best senior thesis in
African Studies at Harvard College

**Harvard Business School** — Cambridge, MA
Research Assistant for Hakeem Belo-Osagie — Spring 2026, 2025
Business & Entrepreneurship in Africa

**Harvard Department of Economics** — Cambridge, MA
Teaching Fellow for Stan Veuger — Fall 2025, 2024
Public Economics: Designing Govt. Policy

**Harvard Department of Government** — Cambridge, MA
Teaching Fellow for Prof. Michael Hiscox — Spring 2025
Evaluating the Impact of Public Policies

**Presentations & Conferences**

**2026** American Political Science Association Annual Meeting; PhD Excellence Initiative Conference, Stanford University
**2025** Harvard Center for African Studies Contested Realities Workshop
**2024** African History Through the Lens of Economics, London Business School; J-PAL Research Staff Training, Massachusetts Institute of Technology
**2022** J-PAL Research Staff Training, Massachusetts Institute of Technology

**Academic Affiliations**

Harvard Center for International Development, PhD Affiliate — August 2025 - Present
Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Graduate Student Associate — August 2024 - Present
Harvard Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Graduate Affiliate — October 2022 - Present
LBS Wheeler Institute's African Research Councillors Programme, Collaborator — May 2022 - Present

**Academic Service**

**Reviewer for**: *The Annual Review of Economics*

**Harvard Concentration Advisor and Non-Resident Tutor** — August 2024 - Present

**Harvard Resident Tutor**, *Winthrop House*
August 2021 - 2023

*Specialties*: French language, public service, first-gen low-income, economics and government

**The Research in Color Foundation** — May 2019 - Present
Founder and President
Since 2019, 95 scholars have benefited from financial assistance and eight months of direct mentorship with economists and quantitative social scientists through my 501(c)(3) non-profit the Research in Color Foundation®. Of those 95, *34 alumni* have started a PhD in economics or an economics-adjacent field. Research in Color has raised over $160,000 in scholarship funding for mentees.

**Selected Experience**

**White House Council of Economic Advisers** *(took leave from PhD)* — Washington, DC
Staff Economist — August 2023 – 2024
Selected Projects: Economic Report of the President, Chapter 5, *Council of Economic Advisers* 2024

**The International Finance Corporation** — Washington, DC
Research Assistant — February – October 2018
Selected Projects: Making It Big: Why Developing Countries Need More Large Firms,*IFC* 2020; Creating Impact: The Promise of Impact Investing, *IFC* 2019; Beyond Capital: Monitoring Development Outcomes of Multinational Enterprises, *World Bank* 2018.

**The World Bank** — Washington, DC
Consultant — June – August 2017
Selected Projects: Surviving Firms of the Syrian Arab Republic, World Bank 2018.

**Technical Skills** RStudio, STATA, LaTeX, ArcGIS, Qualtrics, JavaScript, Microsoft Office Suite
**Languages** English (Fluent), French (Upper-intermediate proficiency), Igbo (Passive proficiency)
**Citizenship** United States; Nigeria